# 8

He winced at her hull, straining to think. He again ran through the checklist of possible criticisms or hang ups, dismissing what he knew he had covered. He already had her running to warm up. Shug had fueled her thoroughly, and all her energy cores were charged. He had only about half the tibanna gas she could take, but there had been no shipment yet to top her off, and he had no plans to get into a firefight with anybody today. He'd been so pent up about the whole thing, he'd even cleaned out her insides, clearing out junk from his bunk room and thoroughly scrubbing his sorry excuse for a galley. He wanted–this *needed*–to go well.

Unable to think of anything additional, the restlessness that has chased him all morning returned. He heaved a sigh and paced, his ear still craned to the corridor in anticipation. Only silence met him, and in his boredom, he traced the hexagonal pattern of the deep grout lines on the floor with his toe.

Out beyond his peripheral, Mako's bay sat empty. Good thing; he'd try to stay mum about this venture for fear of jinxing it–he didn't much believe in fate, but he did believe in consequences–and he didn't trust himself to resist the urge to prematurely posture in front of Spince.

Even Salla didn't know. He'd not lied, she'd just never asked why he'd talked to Rho that night. In fairness, she usually didn't inquire; the two of them lived their lives without much overlap or check in. It just wasn't like that. Although…she *had* looked at him differently the next morning, smiling so strangely as she announced she'd delay her trip a couple days to match his schedule before dropping a kiss on his cheek. To think on it again, to feel his shoulders clench now the way they had as soon as he'd noticed, to recall how he'd tried to laugh off his unease…he bit at the inside of his cheek. Maybe it was time to get even busier.

At the shuffle of approaching footsteps in the distance, Han picked up his head and watched Rho amble in, grunting in discomfort

as he did so, but soon as he met eyes with Han, he beamed. "This walk just gets longer and longer," the old man harrumphed. "Sorry for being late."

"No worries," Han offered. He walked ahead, a bit too fast for Rho, then waited at the gangplank. "I got her warmed up," he reported, reminding himself to smile.

"Yeah, I hear," Rho mumbled breathlessly. "She prepped?"

"Of course," Han chirped, maybe too eagerly. "Uh…fuel, core–"

"Emergency backups?"

Han faltered. One of Rho's first lessons was in thorough readiness–"Can't overprepare!" he'd insisted–and that included double checking all emergency systems and equipment. Even rations had to be ready, just in case. "Don't get caught with your pants around your ankles," he'd said. "Mighty unattractive."

"Yeah." Han gulped through the word despite himself.

The Old Man narrowed his eyes, his tongue massaging his cheek. "I'll take your word for it," he pronounced carefully. "But weapons are up to par, right?"

"I'm at half tibanna," Han admitted. "Nothin' come through yet. There's a hold up–"

"On the Nothoiin," Rho interrupted, a grunt to his voice. "I heard. Warrick's in a tizzy about it."

Warrick. Another name said like Han was supposed to know him. Maybe he did…maybe that was yet another face that Han should recognize because they'd met a time or two.

The Old Man tossed his head. "Well, I ain't too worried about it. Remember– 'you're a smuggler, not a pirate. If you're firing weapons–'"

"'Then you're doin' it wrong,'" Han finished for him.

The Old Man smiled. "Of all the things to teach you, I'm glad that one's up there. Alright. Well, last thing." He stepped up to the gangplank and gripped the hydraulic shaft for support. Han thought for a moment that he was catching his breath, but then watched as

Rho dug into his vest and pulled something out of his pocket.

Han tossed a skeptical glance at the Old Man. "You that worried about this?"

"I don't get on a ship without a toss of the dice, Solo." In a quick jerking motion, he snapped the piece into two, and then dropped the contents of his left hand on the floor. Two dice bounced around at their feet, one landing nearest to the toe of Han's boot. "Now, pick those up for me, will ya?"

Han shook his head with a mocking laugh as he obliged, careful to keep the pieces facing up the way they had landed. He looked at them himself first–two symbols in a scrawling script he did not recognize. Or images? He couldn't tell. "Didn't you say you can't read these?"

"Correct," Rho proclaimed, almost proudly, as he accepted the dice back, laying his palm flat for study. "Not all the way, at least. But Daimon always did this, so I do. That one, see, that one is good. This other one is…I think that's supposed to be a bird. Or…is a comet? Gah, I can't remember. Oh well, so long as it's not double-bad." He clipped their magnetic cord back on. "Okay, let's go."

The 'Suub was on her best behavior as she ascended the atmosphere. They came out into the Black quickly, and then Han steered them in the direction of the Smuggler's Moon L4 libration point. It looked like nothing for a long time, that he was coasting them out into the empty desolation of space, but gradually, the flicker of lights in the distance cleared enough to register that they were not, in fact, twinkling stars, but beacons. Closer, and then chunks of mass appeared to materialize, though still difficult to distinguish out the view window. He flew them even closer, then came to as much of a standstill as he could in zero gravity to survey.

Out before them stretched the practice runs, 'Wreck-creation Station' as some jokingly called them: obstacle courses laid out so the smugglers could keep their skills and reaction time honed in realtime that made them better judges of preparedness than the sims. These runs, constructed over the years by every stray piece of flotsam and

jetsam that inevitably ended up in the gravity well of a large body, offered the perfect place to learn to maneuver, to test one's reflexes, or to try out a new part or software upgrade or sensor to see if it would stand the true test of a run or flight. An actual job, amongst space rock and black holes and pirates, was not the place to find out that you or your ship weren't ready. Practice Run 6, in particular, was said to be the closest equivalent to flying through the Pit, as it sat on the edge of the libration point and thus the objects that made up the course churned with an unpredictable ferocity.

Han flexed his fingers in his gloves, mindlessly pulling them down tighter, aware of the sweat already on his palms. He tried to steady his breath, then remembered his training and controlled his breathing, in and out, to force his heart rate to slow. There was no room for nerves out here; nerves got people killed. He flew best when he was out of his head, when his moves were more automatic than conscious, when he connected to the ship. Everything else was clutter. Dangerous.

"Ready when you are," Rho announced, his eyes already hovering over his screens, ready to perform as copilot.

Han brought the 'Suub forward, letting her coast to about half a kilometer from the starting marker of the practice run, a defunct comm satellite that hovered in stillness despite the chaos behind it. Even as they watched, a little piece of jetsam crashed into the satellite, jarring it out of place, and then its thrusters kicked on, returning it to position. The start and end markers always kept the same distance from each other–time on the run meant as much as successful completion. He would throw thrusters on full blast and go barreling past the entrance when he was ready…same as was required on the real thing.

The sublight engines familiarly vibrated the whole chassis as Han prepped them to engage. He did another quick survey of the field–what in his immediate view could he take stock of, what would come crossing his trajectory and when. He could not see much–that was the shit part about flying in space, everything was so damn

invisible–but he did pick out a long piece of something tumbling its way toward them far off on his starboard side. He could miss it if he hurried. His hand reached for the thrusters.

"Hold!" Rho ordered, his hand coming up to quiet any questioning from Han. "Somethin' way off out there. Something *big*." Rho picked his head up from a vector screen, squinting out the view shield, and then his arm extended across Han's nose, pointing far out to port in the direction of the hyperspace entrance. "There."

Han followed the line of the arm, unable to distinguish what the older man had discerned, but then he caught it–the faintest flash of light blue off the hull of a sizable spacecraft, and the flickering of red off the smaller ships that followed. Han's blood ran cold at the sight. Pirates. Drea, specifically.

"Do we bolt?!" Han queried, ready to turn the ship around and dash back down to the surface.

Rho watched for a beat…then two. His eyes narrowed. "They got the whole damn flotilla with them. If they're out prowling, they ain't after small fish. But let's not sit here–let 'er rip!"

The both of them fell back in their seats as the engines went full burn. At the cross of the start line, a timer clicked on above Han's head, which he quickly acknowledged, then he tipped the 'Suub on her side to miss a tumbling piece of metal–a claw of some kind from a crawler. Rho called out to him a handful of other object coordinates, making clear they seemed small, and Han sped her up even further and banked her again in a coordinated, smooth maneuver. A larger piece came at them, barreling down from his zenith, and Han pulled her back, letting the broken hull from some Republic-era ship sweep past.

"Keep your eye on the right wing," Rho advised, steady but scrutinizing. "Fore, Vector Two."

Han's eye clocked the object–it was hurtling its way forward ahead of his nose, crossing to the starboard side–and it would rip the front off his ship if he didn't adjust accordingly. He drove forward, turning the ship all the way on her side. The controls strained under

his hands, fighting him, but they cleared the piece, if only by a couple meters, and he heard Rho tightly curse at him under his breath. Han ignored the commentary, his attention honed in only to process the area before him, and even managed to sidestep a little chunk of something that his shields would have easily bounced off. The ‘Suub had finesse, and he wanted Rho to know it.

The coordinates continued to come in–Aft, Vector 2, which he artfully sped up from, then dodged around a spent fuel cell from below his portside. Han pressed forward, dipping under a sheet of hull from an ancient Separatist droid ship and spinning the ‘Suub just in time to dodge a floating slab of engine casing. The ship groaned, her metal skeleton protesting under the speed and the stress of Han's maneuvers.

“*Easy*, Solo,” Rho warned, glaring sideways at him. “Sorosuubs ain’t built for this.”

True, most weren’t, but he’d not sunk as much time into his ship to not have her cooperate. Another large hunk of hull plating spun slowly in his path, and he pulled the ship into a hard bank, veering just close enough that the stabilizers almost bucked. He let the ship’s thrusters breathe in the open space before dropping her into another tight turn, ducking through a pair of twisted engine turbines.

“She’s got a nice response time,” Han announced. “Would be even better if she had a little more speed to burn.”

Despite his focus, Rho managed to chuckle. “More speed and she’d fly herself apart.”

Han’s humor dimmed: he felt an instinctual twinge at Rho’s comment, a warning not to push her too far. He could make it work, though; he could think two steps ahead, measuring and timing the gaps between spinning debris with each move. She’d get there, he affirmed distantly. She had to.

Ahead of them awaited the finish line, its beacon obscured by a web of jagged metal scraps. They spun in slow motion, leaving only a narrow window to access the signal of the beacon. Han’s eyes

darted up to the clock–he was two minutes and counting, and he'd not be worth his salt if he didn't finish in less than three. He watched again their murky turning, intuiting his best approach, and gunned the throttle, aiming to slice through the gap with split-second precision. Surging forward, the ship pulled against him slightly–some kind of hiccup in the engines–and his hands flew across his instrumentals, adjusting the power distribution so as not to lose speed.

Rho leaned forward, and his voice came out strained. "Too much! Pull back!"

The ship shuddered as they barreled toward the gap. And then the system power flickered–just a flash–but enough to make Han's heart skip. He gritted his teeth: he couldn't let the ship's limitations press down on his plans.

"Solo, pull back! She can't make that."

"She *can*," he insisted, rolling his shoulders and setting his focus forward.

Yet the shuddering intensified. The ship howled with sounds he'd not heard her make before. At the last second, he abandoned the tactic, easing off the throttle so he could bank the ship the long way around the tangled mess of debris. His pulse hammering in his ears, he heard the beep above them as they crossed the finish line, and immediately checked the timer. 3:17.

"Fuck!" he barked, throwing himself back in his captain's chair as momentum carried them away from the course.

Rho eyed him disapprovingly, one brow raised. "You did the smart thing."

"Let me do it again!" Han begged as he sat back up. "Seeing Drea threw me off–"

"There'll be pirates around Kessel, and in and around the entrance to The Run," Rho chided, then shook his head with a huff as he gazed around the cockpit with chagrin. "Besides, that ain't it."

Han's chest seized. "Ain't it?!"

Rho smashed his lips together, holding in what he understood

would be unwelcome news for as long as he could bear. He tightly shook his head. No words necessary.

"But I upgraded her core!" Han protested. "Rewired the whole system–"

"Putting tits on a bull ain't gonna make it give you milk." Rho's words came out quick and harsh, an unexpected escalation that caused Han to snap his head away. "I'm sorry, Han, I–"

"We only did it *once*." Han's voice came out strained over the cord wrapped tight at his larynx. "How could you–"

"*Because*, Han. I know. That's why people ask me to train them. Why you asked me." At the younger man's stiff silence, Rho huffed, then continued, strained. "Why the hell do you think I agreed to take you in the first place?! I knew if I didn't, you'd do something dumb like go on your own. It was either take you and let you see it yourself or I was gonna get wind after the fact that you were stardust. I needed you to *feel* it," the Old Man stressed, his one hand lifting and tightening into a fist while the other clamped on Han's nearest knee. "You gotta understand what she demands and how quickly she'll take from you."

Staring out into the Black, Han's chin wavered. Rho had given his judgement with such finality, but that couldn't be true. It *couldn't* be.

Seeing the younger man recoil, Rho softened. "I'm sorry, Han. I know you did a lot of work with her–she's probably a hell of a lot better now than when she came off the line. Flies pretty damn good for being a 'Suub, if I'm honest." He shook his head again. "But she won't cut it. She never could. Not out there. Not on a Kessel Run."

They sat in silence for a while, Han staring out the view window while he chewed on his lip. He had a heat at his chest and a churning in his belly while his thoughts rushed, too quick to actually catch, in an exhaustive effort to think up some alternate recourse or argument. Eventually, he wore himself out, and reclined in his seat with a pant of bitter acceptance. Rho knew what he was talking

about, and yes, he'd already exhausted his options to improve his little *Starmite*. He sat there for a moment longer, nodding slightly as his reality sank in. Fine, a ship that couldn't take him all the way. What then?

"I put a lot of money in her," he started, his timbre low and tightly controlled. "Like you said…fixed her up real good. I could catch a good price for her."

"Ain't no one gonna buy this ship," Rho tutted.

At this, Han balked. "*I* did."

Rho guffawed first. "Yeah, Ploy found a desperate sucker that day. Someone who didn't know any better. Little shit, that's why he's gone–you can't do business like that and stay around for long. Hope the sap who bought him out doesn't repeat." For a beat, he paused, stewing briefly, then sighed as he turned to the pilot. "Listen, Han, Hutt Space is big, but you know we all talk. She's got a stink on her that goes as far as Wobani. Anybody who knows about her won't want her for her track record, and anybody who don't won't wanna pay the price you're asking."

Han frowned. "How do you know what price I'm gonna ask?"

"I know you're not stupid enough to take a loss on her," Rho answered, brows raised, trying to humor. "And her market value would put you at a pretty big damn loss."

"So, what?" Han rebuffed, flustered, "I'm just stuck with her?"

"Why do you gotta be *stuck* with her?" Rho rejoined. "You been all over with her. She's good! You busted your ass to get her like this, and now, you ain't happy?"

"Not if I'm flying a ship with clipped wings. She can't ev–"

Rho threw his hands down to interrupt. "What's the last place you came from?"

This question surprised Han. He retreated, then his voice came out small. "RN II."

"And how fast d'you make it back?"

Han's lips pursed, aware now of where Rho was heading. "Two hours," he admitted.

"Two hours. Two…all the way back from RN. When's the last time she had to fight anybody off?"

This, Han had to think about. "Two months ago. Buyers tried to stiff us out of payment. Ambush. We skirted out of there still with the goods. They pursued, but we lobbed 'em off."

Rho stared a breath, his point made. "Seems like you got a good damn ship under you. You know her guts, you know her quirks, you know her limits. That takes *time*, Han…that don't come easy. Don't be so quick to jump outta her into something else, like that don't have consequences of its own."

Han's eyes danced around the Old Man's face, searching for the opener he needed to rebut, but instead, his gaze fell. He breathed hard through his nose, his mouth contorting as he gripped his arm rest.

"D'you know what I think?" Rho started, his voice warm.

Han was quiet a few too many beats, but he finally grunted his curiosity.

Rho leaned over. "I think you're a great pilot, Han. Good head, great reflexes. You should be proud–don't let nothin' tell you otherwise."

Han felt like he was supposed to meet Rho's gaze, but he tried and found he couldn't. Every muscle of his instead screamed to keep his chin down and his face placid, to make his mind go blank and his chest devoid of feeling, to wait, to hover, to not exist temporarily, until what wave of sentiment that crashed against him, trying for an opening, gave up and receded. Only when it did, only when he'd successfully steeled himself against expression, did he finally fleetingly offer Rho his small thanks.

He could see Rho nod a few times in reception, then the Old Man's attention flitted out the view window for a bit. "I ain't big on doling out unsolicited advice," he continued breathily, "but I am gonna tell you this: you could use a gunner. The shields on this ship can't take too many hits, and you don't have free hands to fire back. Two people is not enough for a crew on her."

Han recoiled at the idea. "Mako doesn't have a gunner. Salla doesn't–"

"And if you were flying a ship like either of theirs, we wouldn't be having this conversation. I like this little ship, but let's stay real, Han, this thing is a tin can. You can buy whatever shields and plating you want, but she can only hold so much. A lick-o-laser from a turbocanon like I've seen on some of these crate-stealers, and you guys are smoked."

Han could only frown. "I already got one too many people on my ship, and there ain't no gettin' rid of him."

Rho tittered, rubbing at his knee as he adjusted in his seat. "Alright, alright. I won't push." His gaze swept back out the view window. He settled, contemplative. "We ain't had much of a chance to chat like this for a while," he added, wistful.

Nervousness tickled Han's stomach: nothing good ever started with words like those. He braced slightly, sitting up more in his seat.

Rho seemed to not notice. "Just so it's out in the open, words have passed my ears about what brought you to Nar Shaddaa. About your time in the service." He turned to face Han, raising his brows. "You ain't been mad at me, have you?"

The question threw Han, made his anxiety fall away in the face of befuddlement. "M-mad at you?" he sputtered. "Why would I be mad at you?"

Rho shrugged. "'Cause maybe you believed I told 'em. That I let it slip. So we're clear, I didn't."

Han spun in his seat to face the Old Man head on, his jaw slack for a beat as all his thoughts hurried to catch up. "Wait–you knew?!"

Rho flinched with insult. "Of course I knew!"

"Since when?!"

"Since you got here!"

Han stared again, aghast. "And you didn't *say* anything?!"

Rho shrugged, nonchalant and maybe even humored. "Was pretty clear to me you didn't want to talk about nothin' when you first

came. And I'll be frank–I don't care. All of us got some kinda something hiding in our closets. Nobody comes to the Smuggler's Moon because everything in their life went right."

Han's mouth slid to the side in a sarcastic tilt. "Do you tell the Nar Shaddese that?"

Rho snorted. "Can't tell the Nar Shaddese nothin'. *But*...theirs is a pretty sorry lot. Hard to hold it too much against them if they get fussy over us off-worlders." Rho looked him over. "D'you know who did?"

"Run their mouth?" Han clarified, then rolled his eyes. "The Hutts are...messy."

"To put it lightly," the Old Man added, then he snickered again.

The two of them sat for a few more seconds of quiet. Eventually, Han couldn't help himself. "What gave me away?" he asked with a small, sheepish smile.

Rho laughed first, then answered through a wry grin. "You came here in shiny black boots and a clean shave. What do you all call that–squared away? *And* you follow process–most of these mudslingers don't know how."

Han fell back in his seat, stunned, though it slid quickly into a half-smile. "That's funny," he said with a slight daze. "I thought...I thought *you'd* be mad."

Rho's gaze turned to him and lingered, something calculating behind his eyes. "If I'd've been mad, believe me, you woulda known." He inhaled big and long. "Well, now that's it out, you wanna at least tell me about your time in the clutch?"

There was no stopping the double-take this time; he'd never told anybody here *what* he'd flown. Even Mako didn't know he'd sat in a TIE.

Rho sniggered again at Han's reaction. "Figured it, the first couple times we flew together. Those little 'through' maneuvers you like so damn much–that's a telltale sign."

Despite himself, Han chuckled. "I didn't learn that with the

Imps. That's all swoop."

"Now *that* I see in your hands." Those bushy, grey brows raised again. "I've wondered about that, too. Swoop's a rough sport–how'd you get into that?"

*Didn't have much choice*, was the first answer that came to Han, but he didn't…he didn't want to say that. Instead, he sat forward, hunching his shoulders as he parsed through exactly how to phrase it. "I guess…I guess I just fell into it." He skipped over Shrike's name. "Guy who I was with used to go hang out at the races, and I'd tag along sometimes."

Rho smiled. "Bonding time?"

*Not really*, Han winced, chewing at his lip as snippets of memory came to him. Money traded fast at the races, and everybody came with credits on them. Han's fast, little hands and his eye for observation had made him quite adept at unburdening others from their gambling funds, and he proved quick, too, at scrambling away or feigning innocence. If and when things escalated, and sometimes they did–he had a scar on his shoulder from the slash of a vibroblade bestowed upon him by a particularly cantankerous Arcona–Shrike would storm in and throw a fit, choosing according to each situation if Han was to be protected against a *clearly* mistaken and drunken fool or an upstart little kid who had wandered too far and needed a thrashing. Watching Han take the hits from Shrike usually made the others back off.

Han continued, pushing past Rho's assertion. "We were in the pit one time after a race, just talking to some of the teams, and I saw my chance. Never been on a bike before, it was all a stretch for me–I was a little too small–but I took off. Fucked around on it the whole rest of the night until it ran outta fuel. Left it somewhere safe, and then stayed out as late as I could. I knew I'd get whooped hard and was trying to put it off. But I came back and that guy was waiting for me at the door. Said I was gonna get back on the bike–my own. Said I was gonna race." He grinned, a smile strung somewhere between melancholy and nostalgia. "Threw me on a bike, made me figure it

out, and…that's what I did."

"Destiny!" Rho chuckled. "You had to have been good."

"I was great," Han mused quietly, slightly flush. "Did tournaments–traveled around and raced in the junior leagues. I won–a lot."

"Well, hot damn." Rho sat back in surprise, his palms opening. "What happened?"

Han lobbed his head to the side, unsure again how much to say. If he mentioned Shrike, Rho would ask. That would mean even more questions, more memories that he wasn't especially in the mood right now–ever?–to crack back open.

"Got tired of taking orders," he finally settled on. "Didn't want someone else deciding when I raced, who I raced, how I spent my winnings." *Didn't want to be a cash cow anymore*, he admitted then, trying to not get too bent out of shape about it. *Or a punching bag*.

"You really jumped from the frying pan to the fryer there, didn't you?" Rho surmised, chuckling. "Wouldn't exactly call time in the Blue Shirts as *liberated*."

Han flustered a little, though still managed a smile. "Yeah. I don't know, I knew they'd be strict. I guess I didn't mind strict, really, if it made sense. Maybe I needed strict, I just thought it came with…benefits, you know? Follow the rules, endure the hardship, get the reward?" His eyes widened with sarcasm. "Not that *that* worked out."

"Where'd you serve?"

Han inhaled long at the question as he accessed the memories. "First assignment, did patrol in the Core on a beat up old Praetor."

"*Praetor?*" Rho blurted. "I thought they'd phased them all out by now."

Rho's comment elicited a snort of derision from Han. "They should, for as much as they take care of 'em. Thirty years is a long time to leave a ship up in the Black."

He smiled then, his fingers running over his chin as he remembered the *Valiant*. She was no pushover, but it was like the

Empire had given up any intention of maintaining her. He could remember talking to some of the people in engineering, bitching about how screwed they'd be if they ever actually saw combat. Even when they tried, even when orders went through, the Imps back in Command on Coruscant were always cutting corners on her, always chasing cost-saving measures. Bureaucrats.

"How long d'you serve?" Rho continued.

The question pulled Han from his reverie. "Uh…did two years at the Academy and then about two years and change of duty."

"The Academy?" Rho straightened in his seat with incredulity.

"First in my class," Han announced, hollow, followed by a snicker. "You have to do a few test flights to get in, one of them on Coruscant. Proctors threw a fit that I flew *through* Palpatine's Arch of Triumph instead of *over* it. I guess I scared the shit out of all the people below."

Rho heartily chuckled, then sat forward with some seriousness. "Wait, now…so you went to the Academy with Mako? That's how you all know each other?" When Han nodded in affirmation, Rho's brow knit. "Is that true, that story he tells about getting kicked out?"

"About the Mascot Moon? *Yup*."

"Well, I'll be damned," Rho breathed. "I thought for sure he made that up."

Han tilted his head: it wouldn't be the first thing Mako exaggerated. "It was big fuck up. He didn't mean it, just meant to do a prank, but couple people got hurt. Real hurt."

"How the hell he'd get outta something like that?" the Old Man questioned.

Han pursed his lips over the full truth, but flickering his gaze over at Rho's intent, eager stare meant he'd have to give him something. "Mako's…he's more connected than you think. Or *was*, I should say. He used the last of his good will to have that mistake mopped up."

Rho hung on, clearly expecting and maybe even hoping there was more, but as Han didn't budge, the Old Man sat back again. "I see." He cleared his throat. "Well, keep goin'. Did patrol in the Core…"

"Yeah," Han offered. "Uh…it was boring as all hell, running drills all day. I had it in my head that I'd make lieutenant in two years, but we never actually *did* anything to warrant a promotion like that. So I got frustrated, put in a transfer to the Outer Rim and…" His voice fell off for a bit as the visuals came back to him. "Got my eyes opened for me."

"You ever been on the spit?"

Han shook his head. "No, we never saw action." He snorted, dry and sardonic. "Done more shootin' and dodgin' in this 'Suub than I ever did in an Eyeball."

Rho wagged his head. "Well, for the sake of me and mine…I'm sure as hell glad I don't gotta outrun you. Glad you switched sides."

Weary, Han managed a smile. "Yeah. I needed outta there."

"Surprised you didn't try to get back into swoop," Rho inclined. "You're young, you're fit–talented as all hell. You don't have to be out here smuggling. Get back into it."

Han took his time readjusting himself in his seat as he mulled the idea over. It certainly wasn't that he'd never considered it–hell, he'd considered it plenty while he was still *in* the service, on the days when the boredom or the bureaucracy felt especially excruciating. But the possibility of Shrike catching up to him had long given him pause, and now, on top of that, his standing with the Empire…

He winced as he started his response. "All the competitions are in locations that I, uh…I could *go*, and as long as I kept my head down, I think I'd be fine. But these racers, the winners–they're famous. I can't be famous in Empire territory, and there's no point in swoop racing–there's no money–if you don't win." He forced a grin. "So it's slinging crates and dodging pirates for me."

"Pirates," Rho snarked, yet his face quickly fell and his eyes

grew distant. He heaved a big sigh, his belly bulging against the console, and Han could see the tension–the worry–at his brow. "I'm going to be honest with you, Solo," he finally said, shaking his finger at the Black, "I ain't seen them come close like that. Not that close, not all together like that. Not Drea, not nobody. Things are gettin' more tenuous out here."

Han's lips pursed: recent Imperial movement on Lothal had kicked up a lot of dust. If they succeeded in their takeover, it would mean the Empire controlled the whole spread of the Perlimian Trade Route and its extension onto the Overic Griplink.

The Old Man shook his head, the tension in him easing only to reveal a weariness. "Man, I don't know. This place ain't like it was when I was comin' up. I mean, the Republic wasn't a cake walk, don't get me wrong, we all still had our tussles with them. But…the Empire is a different kind of beast. They got something extra vicious about 'em, and it makes every other player a new level of dreadful to compensate, and…I just don't know what to make of the field."

"You think the pirates are gonna get worse?"

Rho raised slitted eyes to him. "Pirates, most of 'em at least, prefer an easy quarry, and the Imperials ain't it. The crates-stealers are intrepid, but they ain't suicidal." The old smuggler wilted. "I'm sorry…I just–I don't know if I could have cut it, bein' in your boots. I'll be honest, I don't know how I cut it now. Sometimes…a lot, actually…I've been thinking about something different." Rho dragged a hand over his face and groaned: whatever he was considering, he looked torn about it. "I think I might retire."

"What?!" Han choked out. "Why?"

Rho gazed into the distance. "Been in this industry a long time. I've trained *a lotta* people, been a lotta places. Don't get me wrong, I like most of 'em I meet," he offered, gesturing at Han. "I like you. But it just…it gets tiring. The novelty's worn off." He huffed. "Doesn't help that the job itself sometimes kinda sucks–my body doesn't have it anymore to load crates and climb all over the ship doin' repairs, and–I'm too tired for that. I leave, and while I'm gone–

dammit, I can't believe I'm gonna say it, but—I just want back here. For a long time, gettin' up into the Black meant I was living life fully. But at this point…I feel like I'm always followin' someone else's schedule. I'm tired of bein' on the move all the time. I just want to be in one place for a while. I want to have some kind of my own routine. I don't know how many years I got left in me, but I just want my life to feel like *mine*."

Han flustered. "So, you'd just…*stop*?"

The old smuggler snickered. "Gotta at some point anyway. Rather choose than it done for me."

"You don't think you'd get bored pretty quick?"

Rho brushed the idea off. "Nah. I got plenty to do–I have friends, associates. I'd still get people who ask for me advice–I don't think that'll ever stop. And I have Lwyll." At mention of her, his face changed. The weariness turned to something Han didn't quite know how to place, but the softness was unmissable. "I went out with her last night. We had a great time. She was smilin' and laughin'. She's been upset for a while. About Veno. He pays her like shit. He don't know what he's got. But I had her bustin' up last night."

Han remained still, unsure exactly what to say. He knew enough to know he couldn't tell him *not* to retire; on that, he'd need to keep his preferences to himself. How to lie, then, and fake a smile? How to be happy for someone making choices he couldn't fathom?

"She talks sometimes about opening up her own bakery," Rho continued, clearly ignorant to Han's awkward silence. "I keep tellin' her–she should. She's great in the kitchen: sweet, savory, all of it. She could have her own little place, and just leave Veno's. She don't owe him nothin'. She keeps backing out. Dreams about it, but won't pull the trigger." He snarked then, amused at himself. "Maybe that's what I'd do with myself. Hang up my gloves and just…stay down here, and help her do her own thing."

"D'you really think she'd let you help?" Han interjected, grinning at the playful jab, and he felt relief when Rho responded with a jolly chuckle.

"Probably not," he answered, still tittering. "She'd knock me upside with a baking pan and tell me to get out of her kitchen. But…if I were here, and I finally walked away from smuggling…maybe she'd stop kicking me out of her bed every morning." He hovered on that for a moment, then laughed at himself. "Well, we'll see. I ain't doin' any of it tomorrow. And who even knows–Lwyll always told me she'd want nothin' to do with me so long as I still flew, but I wouldn't put it past her to reneg on all of it if I actually did. Remember what I told you, first time we flew?"

Han searched his memory. "'Don't ever come back empty handed?'"

"No," Rho retorted, then cocked his head. "Well, yes, I do remember saying that. But no: 'there's three things out here you gotta watch out for…'"

"'The pirates, the *yannis*, and the women.'" Han quoted.

Rho snickered. "These Nar Shaddese women sure are a handful. But they're worth it." He hit Han at the knee. "Come on–speaking of her, we better get back. I promised I wouldn't be long."

Han was slow to move, but eventually his arms started to dart around in their hardened routine, engaging his engines back up and directing the 'Suub towards the Spacebarn. They chatted easily as they flew, making trivial conversation as they returned to the surface.

"Well, you have a good rest of the day, Solo," the Old Man started after they had exited the ship. He extended a hand, which Han accepted. "And…hey, don't get too much up in your head about it."

Han sucked in a tight breath at the reminder. "I'll, uh…I'll try not to."

"Good. Remember, 'there's old pilots and there's bold pilots, but there's no old, bold pilots.' I know you ain't gotta death wish–anything but." Rho patted his arm again. "Give Chewie my hellos. And since I'm sure you'll see him before I do, tell Shug I haven't forgotten I owe him a shot of that swill he drinks. Take care."

Han watched the Old Man leave, his tottering figure slowly

shrinking until he disappeared up the lift. Alone, he scratched at his head, then his mouth contorted. Now what?

Without thinking, his hand started to reach for his comm, to check the board, but…he let it instead graze past his pocket. He couldn't bring himself to check it yet. Yes, he had heard Rho loud and clear, and understood how correct many of the Old Man's points had been. He had something good. Reliable. Predictable, in her own way. It would be smart of him to accept that, to keep doing well and just be grateful. And yet, his chest panged, and he mindlessly massaged at the pain.

How to spend the rest of his day, he questioned. He ran through his list of options. No, he'd not take work…not just yet. The sims? That, too, was like a needless goad. This wasn't the place to gamble. He'd see a show, he thought, if there was anything decent around here. His eyes skimmed the bay across from his–*Punching Out* had not yet returned. If he ran into Shug, he'd get roped into helping with something, or maybe worse, adding something else to the 'Suub, and that felt too ironic right now. His mind then flitted over Rho's mention of a gunner. Did he really need that? And where to find one? Who the hell would he trust on that ship with him?

None of it, he decided, clapping his hands together; he wanted nothing to do with any of those questions right now. He wanted to not think about it, to do something else, to…

The plan came to him, vaguely at first, then shockingly clear. He pivoted to check down the hall, confirming that the light above Bay 2 was green, and then before he grasped exactly what he was doing, the message was sent off. He stared at it after, rereading his request to see her, questioning if this was *actually* a good option. He did not like the way she'd regarded him the other morning. Then he forcibly shrugged, the inconvenience brushed away.

A few hours later, when the wine had worn off and the even breathing beside him meant she had fallen deeply asleep, Han winced

into the bright display of his comm. He was frowning, staring hard at the third entry on the job board: *Kessel Run, to Teth*.

He chewed his lip. Was there any way Rho was wrong? Surely, he made mistakes sometimes. Han selected the listing, reading over the specifics. He'd not been approved to take a job at this tier; requesting a change would require a conversation with the Hutts directly. They'd need to do an override first and then, if he proved himself, he'd be cleared. He could go in the morning.

He stared a few moments more, aware of the twisting in his gut. For as much as a very stubborn part of him wanted to select the trip, some other part of him was saying *No*, and firmly. Insisting. He exhaled stiffly, frustrated: he'd not stayed alive this long ignoring his gut.

He backed out of the selection, then did a quick skim of the other availabilities and selected another job for RN II. Without looking twice at it, he let the comm tumble onto the floor, then grabbed the sheets and turned over with a huff.